

WEIGHT LOSS

- Check that the patient that says s/he has unintentionally lost weight has indeed done so. Compare current weight with previous records and ask if clothes still fit.
- Investigate unintentional weight loss of > 5% of body weight.
- Calculate % weight loss = (previous weight - current weight) ÷ previous weight x 100

STEP 1. Check for TB, HIV and diabetes

Exclude TB

- Start workup for TB → 92.
- At the same time, test for HIV and diabetes (see adjacent) and consider other causes below.

Test for HIV

Test for HIV → 110. If HIV positive, give routine care → 111.

Check for diabetes

Check glucose
→ 17.

STEP 2. Then ask about symptoms of common cancers

Abnormal vaginal
discharge/bleeding

Consider **cervical cancer**.
Do a speculum examination and a
cervical screen if needed → 55.

Breast lump/s or nipple discharge

Consider **breast cancer**.
Examine breasts and axillae
for lumps → 43.

Urinary symptoms in man

Consider **prostate cancer**.
Do rectal examination. If hard,
nodular prostate, refer same week.

Change in bowel habit

Consider **bowel cancer**.
If mass on abdominal or
rectal examination or stool occult
blood positive, refer same week.

Cough ≥ 2 weeks, blood-stained
sputum, long smoking history

Consider **lung cancer**.
Do chest x-ray.
If suspicious, refer same week.

STEP 3. Ask if food intake is adequate: if inadequate look for reason:

Nausea or
vomiting

→ 45.

Loss of appetite

- Eat small frequent meals.
- Drink high energy drinks (milk, maas, mageu, soup).
- Increase energy value of food by adding milk powder, peanut butter, oil or margarine.

If stress
or anxiety
→ 86.

No money for food

Refer to social worker to help
organise nutritional support.

The patient has a
life-limiting illness.

Consider giving
palliative care
→ 170.

Sore mouth or
difficulty swallowing

**Oral/oesophageal
candida** likely → 35.

STEP 4. Screen for thyroid problem, depression, substance misuse and neglect:

- Ask about other symptoms and manage as on symptom pages: if abdominal pain → 44, if diarrhoea → 46, if constipation → 48.
- If pulse ≥ 100, palpitations, tremor, dislike of hot weather or thyroid enlargement, check TSH. If abnormal, refer to doctor.
- Review medication: anticonvulsants, antidepressants, diabetes medications and levothyroxine can cause unintentional weight loss. Discuss with doctor.
- Screen for depression: in the past month, has patient: 1) felt down, depressed, hopeless or 2) felt little interest or pleasure in doing things? If yes to either → 143.
- Screen for alcohol/drug use: in the past year, has patient: 1) drunk ≥ 4 drinks¹/session, 2) used illegal drugs or 3) misused prescription or over-the-counter medications? If yes to any → 142.
- Ask about neglect in the older or ill patient needing care. If yes, refer to social worker.

Review in one month. If no better or no cause found, discuss/refer.

¹One drink is 1 tot of spirits, or 1 small glass (125mL) of wine or 1 can/bottle (330mL) of beer.